APPENDIX

Where Structured Literacy Practices Can Drift

Even when teachers are committed to structured literacy, their guidance may vary greatly. Some practices below consume time, attention, and working memory without proportional gain—crowding out others that are needed.

PHONEMIC AWARENESS AND PHONICS

Teaching "blends."
A student who knows the sounds for *s*, *t*, *o*, and *p* already has what's needed to read *stop*. While some students need explicit practice blending adjacent consonants like *st-*, *bl-*, and *tr-*, memorizing 20 or more "blends" imposes an undue burden.

Overdoing oral phonemic awareness—for far too long.
Oral PA gains peak after roughly 10 hours of Tier I instruction; PA integrated with letters is more efficacious. So-called "advanced" PA is generally not useful.

Sound walls: teaching articulatory terminology beyond its instructional payoff.
Mouth pictures and articulation cues can help students tell similar sounds apart. Drilling terms like *bilabial*, *fricative*, or *voiceless alveolar stop* rarely improves reading.

Teaching syllable division as a rule system rather than a flexible aid.
Students may spend excess time marking VC/CV, V/CV, or VC/V divisions as if they determine pronunciation. Stress, morphology, and vowel flexibility often matter more.

Treating six syllable types as a decoding algorithm.
Open, closed, vowel-consonant-e, r-controlled, vowel-team, and consonant-le categories can be useful descriptions. Teachers often overdo them.

Teaching phonics patterns without enough connected-text reading.
Patterns stick best, and words get orthographically mapped, when students meet them repeatedly in connected text.

Inadequate or misaligned spelling instruction.
Encoding—spelling the patterns students are learning—is one of the strongest supports for reading.

MORPHOLOGY AND ORTHOGRAPHY

Ignoring morphology until students are considered "advanced."
A student may be taught to attack *unhelpfulness*, *disagreement*, or *reconstruction* primarily through syllabification even though meaningful units provide a clearer structure. Delaying morphology can make complex words unnecessarily difficult.

Introducing morphology as lists of prefixes and suffixes.
The opposite error also occurs. Students memorize *pre-*, *re-*, *un-*, *-ful*, *-tion* without learning how morphological structure explains meaning, spelling, word families, or pronunciation changes.

Failing to teach morphophonemic change.
In pairs such as *define/definition*, *sign/signature*, *serene/serenity*, and *electric/electricity*, pronunciation shifts while spelling preserves the shared meaning. This helps explain "silent" letters and unclear vowels (*compete → competition*), shows why English spelling cannot be understood solely as sound-to-letter matching, and keeps regular morphological spellings from being taught as "exceptions."

Using "schwa" as an explanation rather than teaching what causes it.
Students may be told that an unstressed vowel "says /uh/" without learning the role of stress, morphology, and word structure. The label names the phenomenon but does not necessarily help them read or spell the word.

Teaching too many heart words or "irregular" word parts.
Words like *have* (English words don't end in *v*) and *two* (*twin*, *twelve*) are often taught as heart words, though their spellings are explainable. When a word breaks an introductory rule, the cause is often stress, morphology, history, or a more advanced correspondence. Calling each case an exception adds memorization and makes English look less systematic than it is.

Overteaching linguistics or etymology.
Explanation can also go too far: rabbit holes into word origins and linguistic processes that don't pay off. An explanation earns its place when it helps students read or spell many words, not just one.

TEXT SELECTION

Equating decodability with instructional suitability.
A text can conform to taught correspondences and still impose awkward syntax, weak vocabulary, low coherence, or excess cognitive load. Conversely, excluding every word containing an untaught pattern can impoverish language and knowledge.

Using controlled text for too long.
Decodable text can be valuable while students consolidate the alphabetic system. If tightly controlled text persists after students can handle broader print, it may constrain vocabulary, syntax, fluency, and knowledge-building.

Moving students out of controlled text too early.
The reverse error leaves students guessing from context because the text contains too many patterns they cannot yet decode reliably.

FLUENCY

Treating oral reading fluency as a single problem.
A low words-correct-per-minute score, or accurate but slow reading, can reflect weak decoding, automaticity, multisyllabic word skill, phrasing, vocabulary, content knowledge, or print exposure. Locate the source before choosing a response.

Accurate decoding ≠ automatic word recognition.
A student who decodes a word correctly may need many more encounters before recognizing it instantly. Check speed as well as accuracy.

Ignoring prosody when assessing fluency.
Appropriate phrasing, pausing, stress, and intonation provide information that accuracy and rate alone miss. Prosody relates meaningfully to comprehension.

Using repeated reading when the bottleneck is decoding.
A student can become faster at a practiced passage without acquiring the word-reading knowledge needed to transfer that improvement to a new passage.

Using round-robin or popcorn reading for oral reading practice.
Each student reads only a few sentences while classmates wait, read ahead, or tune out, and weak readers are exposed rather than supported. Partner, choral, and echo reading give every student far more practice.

VOCABULARY, KNOWLEDGE, AND COMPREHENSION

Underteaching oral language.
Many students lag in spoken language. Listening comprehension should be explicitly built from K up, via read-alouds, discussion, prompted storytelling, and extended talk.

Teaching vocabulary as isolated definitions.
Students may copy definitions, match words to meanings, or memorize weekly lists without learning semantic relationships, morphology, multiple meanings, collocations, or the knowledge domain in which the words are useful.

Underteaching academic vocabulary.
Words such as *analyze*, *contrast*, *infer*, *significant*, and *establish* occur across subjects and carry much of the meaning in textbooks, directions, assignments, and tests.

Trying to activate knowledge instead of building it.
Students cannot activate knowledge they do not have.

Teaching comprehension through excessive strategy rehearsal.
Predicting, questioning, summarizing, and identifying main ideas can help students learn how comprehension works. Once students understand a strategy, more practice yields little. The time is better spent building vocabulary and knowledge.

Teaching "main idea" as though it were independent of knowledge.
Students may be asked to infer main ideas from passages about topics they barely understand, making a knowledge deficit look like a strategy deficit.

Underteaching sentence structure.
Students may know every word in a sentence and still misunderstand who did what to whom, which idea modifies which, or how one clause relates to another. Passive voice, relative clauses, embedded clauses, and connectives such as *although*, *unless*, and *despite* can trip up many learners.

Underteaching text structure.
A text's organization (comparison, cause-effect, problem-solution) shows how its ideas connect. Students who learn to spot it from signal words (*because*, *in contrast*) can better grasp the gist and remember what they read.

Overteaching grammatical labels.
Students can spend substantial time naming predicates, subordinating conjunctions, or clause types without getting better at understanding or writing hard sentences.

PROGRAMS, ASSESSMENT, AND INTERVENTION

Assuming a program scope and sequence = a knowledge model.
A commercial program necessarily makes sequencing choices. Those choices may be sensible, but teachers can begin treating one program's terminology, order, and routines as though they represented settled findings about reading development.

Treating fidelity as immunity from error.
Implementation fidelity is useful only if the underlying practice is well matched to the student and the evidence. Perfectly implementing the wrong response simply produces consistent inefficiency.

Assigning intervention when Tier I instruction needs improvement.
If more than ~20% of students are struggling, the grade-level team should review core instruction wrt pacing, content, sequencing, instructional time, and delivery.

Three tiers does not mean three programs.
Unrelated programs at each tier give struggling students conflicting routines and terminology. Intervention works best when it reinforces core instruction.

Responding to every error with immediate correction.
Constant interruption undermines fluency and comprehension. Teachers need guidance on which errors matter and when to step in.

Treating a screening score as a diagnosis.
Two students with the same screening score may struggle for very different reasons: weak phoneme-grapheme knowledge, slow automatic recognition, language disorder, limited vocabulary, etc. Good diagnostic assessments should precede intervention; core instruction may also need adjustment.

Undiagnosed DLD.
More than 7% of kids have Developmental Language Disorder. The earlier it's diagnosed, the better. Yet many schools don't screen early enough, treating language difficulties as generic reading problems.

Continuing "evidence-based" instruction without checking response.
Population-level evidence does not guarantee that a particular routine remains useful for a particular student. Instruction should change when progress data show that the presumed mechanism is not producing the expected result.

This appendix contains significant AI text. It is the authors' hope that you, the experts, will embrace this as a community, and build it to better tell the story.